



STEPPE

Grant Applications Pack

Ready-to-adapt letters

REDMOND • CENTRAL OREGON • EST. 2026

v3 • 2026-07-09

A member-governed Oregon public benefit nonprofit.

Internal note • 2026-07-09. Working draft, converted from Word to Markdown and rebranded to Steppe. Facts to rely on: the fiscal sponsor is **Ignite Empowerment Foundation**, a Central Oregon 501(c)(3) (EIN 99-3872440), with the sponsorship agreement pending signature. Director Brandon Weimer is the spouse of the foundation's founder, so Steppe and the foundation handle their arrangement as a disclosed related party (see docs/governance/). Dues are **\$4 a month**. The founding board is Chism, Cobb, and Weimer, with a fourth independent director planned. Before sending this to a funder, apply the open items in docs/funding/funder-pack-corrections-v1.md (grant-ask sizing, board-independence wording, and the 2026 pipeline dates).

STEPPE

Grant Applications Pack — v3

June 2026 · Six ready-to-send documents · Complete bracketed fields, verify portal requirements, submit

- **Document A** — Roundhouse Foundation — Small Grants Letter of Inquiry (submit on sponsorship signing; rolling through Nov 30)
- **Document B** — Roundhouse Foundation — Fall Open Call proposal narrative (window open now through August)
- **Document C** — Ford Family Foundation — program-officer inquiry letter (send before any application)
- **Document D** — Local & corporate one-page ask (Central Electric Cooperative, First Interstate, and peers)
- **Document E** — College & makerspace partnership inquiry — COCC and OSU-Cascades (opens the MOU conversation; send H2 2027 or earlier if doors open)
- **Document F** — Fiscal-sponsorship inquiry — Connect Central Oregon or a referred Central Oregon 501(c)(3) (the critical-path funding document; send this month)

A --- Roundhouse Foundation: Small Grants LOI

USE Submit through the Roundhouse online grants portal as soon as the fiscal sponsorship agreement is signed. Rolling review; decisions in roughly 8-12 weeks. Ask: \$12,500 (Package A — Launch Capacity). Tone matches their grassroots, rural-rooted culture: concrete, local, unpretentious.

Dear Roundhouse Foundation team,

Steppe is community-owned digital infrastructure for the towns of Central Oregon — a verified, ad-free platform where neighbors share events, needs, and community decisions, governed by the members themselves. We are writing to request \$12,500 in launch support as we bring the platform to Redmond this fall.

Central Oregon's rural communities have no shared information space they own or trust. The platforms that fill the gap answer to advertisers, not residents — and they serve our region's working towns worst of all. Nearly a third of Madras residents speak Spanish at home, and almost nothing in the local information landscape does. Steppe was built to fix the ownership problem underneath the information problem: an Oregon nonprofit with no shareholders, commitments

against advertising and data sale written into its articles, \$4-a-month dues that fund operations permanently, and surplus flowing to local charities chosen by member vote.

The platform is already built and security-audited: residency verification, neighborhood events for 35 mapped Redmond neighborhoods, secret-ballot community voting, due-process moderation, Spanish localization, and accessibility support. Our founding board is rooted here — Holli Cobb, founder of Redmond Compass, and Brandon Weimer, owner of Herringbone Books in Redmond, alongside founding director Greg Chism. Redmond Compass is our launch partner.

A Roundhouse grant would close the last gaps between a working platform and a publicly trustworthy one: a professional native-speaker review of our Spanish dictionary, an accessibility and contrast audit, training for our first volunteer moderators, plain-language legal review, first-year insurance and hosting, and bilingual outreach materials. Dues will carry these costs in future years; this grant carries them to launch.

We launch in Redmond in late 2026, expand only by community petition and vote, and are capped by our own charter at twelve towns — built to serve this place deeply rather than scale past it. We would be glad to share our governance charter, security audit, or a demonstration, and we welcome a conversation at your convenience.

With appreciation for your consideration,

Greg Chism

Founding Executive Director, Steppe

[EMAIL] · [PHONE] · [WEBSITE]

Fiscally sponsored by [SPONSOR NAME], EIN [SPONSOR EIN], pending Steppe's 501(c)(3) determination (Form 1023 filed [DATE]).

B --- Roundhouse Foundation: Fall Open Call Narrative

USE The fall Open Call window is open June–August 2026. Ask: \$48,000 over two years (Package B). Sections below map to standard portal prompts — adapt headings to their application form. Pair with the budget table from the Master Case §05.

Project Title

Civic Infrastructure for Rural Central Oregon: A Community-Owned Platform, From Redmond Outward

Need Statement

Central Oregon's rural towns are losing the connective tissue that healthy communities run on. Local news has retrenched; the national platforms that filled the vacuum are engineered for outrage, owned elsewhere, and accountable to no one here. The cost lands hardest in the working communities — Redmond, Sisters, La Pine, Madras, Prineville, Terrebonne, Culver — where coverage is thinnest, where a third of Madras residents speak Spanish at home and the civic information layer doesn't, and where wildfire seasons make trustworthy local information a safety issue, not a convenience. The deeper problem is ownership: every platform serving the region extracts from it. Information infrastructure failed Central Oregon because of who owns it.

Project Description

Steppe answers the ownership problem directly: a member-governed Oregon nonprofit operating a verified, ad-free community platform. Residents verify local residency, pay \$4 a month, and get a calm, chronological space for neighborhood events, mutual exchange, and binding community votes — with full Spanish access, due-process moderation, and quarterly public transparency reports. The commitments that matter — no advertising ever, member-owned data, community control — are written into our articles of incorporation; surplus revenue flows to local charities the members choose by ranked-choice vote. The platform is complete and security-audited as of June 2026, with 35 Redmond neighborhoods mapped and Redmond Compass as our launch partner.

This grant funds the two-year program that turns a launched platform into rural civic infrastructure. Year one places a part-time community coordinator in Redmond to build the founding cohort, support volunteer moderators, and run neighborhood outreach — and carries structured listening sessions to six rural towns so that expansion, when those communities petition for it, is shaped by what they actually said. Year two sustains the coordinator and adds a paid internship pilot: two Central Oregon students, in technology and community tracks, paid above minimum wage, finishing with a public showcase — the platform maintained by the community's own young people.

Community Benefit

Direct benefit flows to Redmond's ~36,000 residents at launch and to the rural towns in the listening-session circuit. Specific populations served: Spanish-speaking households (full localization, professionally reviewed), residents excluded by standard verification systems (PO box and non-standard-document accommodation with human review), and rural young people (paid internships). Structural benefit flows to all of Central Oregon: a permanent, locally-owned alternative to extractive platforms, with a governance model published openly for any rural community to adopt.

Outcomes & Evaluation

- 200 verified members by mid-2027 (~0.5% of Redmond) and 100 by end of 2026
- Six rural-town listening sessions completed, findings published
- Quarterly bilingual transparency reports, on schedule, every quarter
- First binding community votes held, with turnout and appeal-vs-exit rates published
- Two paid internships completed with public showcase (year two)

All measures run on the platform's own public health dashboard — funders read the same numbers members do.

Sustainability

Member dues fund core operations permanently; this grant funds capacity that dues cannot yet reach. By the grant's end, dues at the 200-500 member level carry the coordinator role into the operating budget, and the internship program transitions to a mix of dues surplus and dedicated workforce-development funding. By rule, no single funder may exceed 30% of our annual revenue — a Roundhouse award extends the commons; it never becomes its dependency.

C --- Ford Family Foundation: Program-Officer Inquiry

USE Send by email before any application; their staff explicitly welcome pre-application contact. Purpose: settle the rural-eligibility question honestly and identify the right door (Good Neighbor vs. Technical Assistance). Short and direct — it requests a conversation.

Subject: Eligibility inquiry — community-owned civic platform serving rural Central Oregon

Dear [PROGRAM OFFICER NAME],

I'm writing to ask for fifteen minutes of guidance before we apply, because I want to be straightforward about geography rather than frame around it.

Steppe is a new member-governed Oregon nonprofit operating a community-owned, ad-free digital platform — verified local membership, \$4-a-month dues, community voting, full Spanish access, and surplus revenue flowing to local charities by member vote. We launch this fall in Redmond, which I recognize sits at the edge of your rural definition. The project's horizon, though, is Central Oregon's unambiguously rural towns — Sisters, La Pine, Madras, Prineville, Terrebonne, Culver — which join by community petition and vote, and our first grant-funded program carries structured listening sessions to those six communities so expansion is shaped by their residents. Madras matters particularly to us: a third of its residents speak Spanish at home, and our platform is fully localized.

My questions: whether work of this shape — launched from Redmond, designed for and expanding into your rural footprint — can meet your 60% rural-benefit standard; and whether the better first conversation is a Good Neighbor grant for the rural listening and outreach program, or a Technical Assistance grant for organizational capacity (we are a young organization, under \$1M, with formation, fundraising systems, and board development needs a consultant could meaningfully accelerate).

I'd welcome a call at your convenience, and I'm happy to send our governance charter and case for support in advance.

With appreciation for your consideration,

Greg Chism

Founding Executive Director, Steppe

[EMAIL] · [PHONE] · [WEBSITE]

Fiscally sponsored by [SPONSOR NAME], EIN [SPONSOR EIN], pending Steppe's 501(c)(3) determination (Form 1023 filed [DATE]).

D --- Local & Corporate One-Page Ask

USE For Central Electric Cooperative, First Interstate, Mid Oregon Credit Union, and peers. Asks of \$1,000-\$5,000. Swap the bracketed opening per recipient; the CEC variant leads with the cooperative kinship — it's genuine and it lands.

Dear [NAME / COMMUNITY GIVING COMMITTEE],

[CEC VARIANT: As a member-owned cooperative, you've spent eighty years proving that essential infrastructure can belong to the people it serves. Steppe is that same idea, applied to how our

communities share information.] [GENERAL VARIANT: Steppe is bringing a new kind of community infrastructure to Redmond this fall, and we're inviting a small group of trusted local institutions to help launch it.]

Steppe is a verified, ad-free community platform owned by its members — an Oregon nonprofit where Redmond residents share neighborhood events, trade needs and offers, and make community decisions by vote. The charter bars advertising and data sales; dues of \$4 a month fund operations; and surplus flows to local charities our members choose. Our founding board is Redmond through and through: Holli Cobb of Redmond Compass and Brandon Weimer of Herringbone Books, alongside founder Greg Chism. The platform is built, security-audited, fully bilingual, and launches publicly in late 2026.

We're asking [ORGANIZATION] to join the launch with a gift of [\$1,000–\$5,000], directed to [bilingual outreach across Redmond's 35 neighborhoods / volunteer moderator training / our student internship showcase]. Launch supporters are recognized in our public quarterly transparency report — where every dollar we receive and spend is published — and at our community launch events. What we offer in return is the thing itself: infrastructure your members and customers will own.

I'd be glad to come by, give a ten-minute demonstration, and answer anything.

With appreciation for your consideration,

Greg Chism

Founding Executive Director, Steppe

[EMAIL] · [PHONE] · [WEBSITE]

Fiscally sponsored by [SPONSOR NAME], EIN [SPONSOR EIN], pending Steppe's 501(c)(3) determination (Form 1023 filed [DATE]).

E --- College & Makerspace Partnership Inquiry

USEFor COCC (CTE dean / CIS chair) and OSU-Cascades (makerspace director) — adapt the bracketed opening per recipient. This is not a funding ask; it opens the MOU conversation: internship alignment, makerspace access, and Steppe's community-partner role in regional grant work. Send when the 2027 partnership window opens, or earlier if a door opens naturally.

Subject: Partnership inquiry — community internships, makerspace collaboration, and a community anchor for regional grant work

Dear [NAME],

I direct Steppe, a member-governed Oregon nonprofit operating a community-owned civic platform that launched in Redmond in late 2026 — verified local membership, no advertising by charter, full Spanish access, and community decisions made by member vote. [COCC VARIANT: With your Manufacturing & Applied Technology Center and Redmond Technology Education Center anchoring the technical-education landscape in our launch town, a conversation feels overdue.] [OSU-CASCADES VARIANT: Your makerspace's trained-student client-project model is, frankly, the apprenticeship pattern our internship program was designed around, and I'd like to explore whether we can build on it together.]

Three concrete things I'd like to discuss. First, internship alignment: Steppe runs paid student internships — technology, community, and data tracks, above minimum wage, ending in a public showcase — maintaining real civic infrastructure the students' own community owns. I'd like those placements to articulate with [CIS 260 / your client-project and capstone structures] so students earn credit and experience in the same motion.

Second, fabrication collaboration: our Connect program deploys community access points — single-board computers in student-designed enclosures — at libraries and community centers in rural towns. We would rather those kits be designed and built by Central Oregon students in Central Oregon shops than purchased from anywhere else, and we can bring grant funding for materials.

Third, the community-anchor role: as your institutions develop regional pathways in data literacy and technician education, federal proposals are strengthened by a community partner that can offer deployment sites, internship placements, and letters of collaboration from a member-governed nonprofit rooted in Redmond. We would welcome that role, formalized by MOU, with no expectation of leading anything.

I'd be glad to come to campus, demonstrate the platform, and hear what would actually be useful to your programs — including the things I haven't thought of.

With appreciation for your consideration,

Greg Chism

Founding Executive Director, Steppe

[EMAIL] · [PHONE] · [WEBSITE]

Fiscally sponsored by [SPONSOR NAME], EIN [SPONSOR EIN], pending Steppe's 501(c)(3) determination (Form 1023 filed [DATE]).

F --- Fiscal-Sponsorship Inquiry

USEThe single most time-sensitive funding document — a fiscal sponsor is the unlock for almost all 2026 institutional money (Roundhouse, OCF). Send this month. First recipient: Connect Central Oregon, which either sponsors directly or refers the best-positioned local 501(c)(3). Keep it short; it asks for a conversation and a yes-or-referral.

Subject: Fiscal-sponsorship inquiry — community-owned civic platform launching in Redmond

Dear [NAME / Connect Central Oregon team],

I'm writing with a specific, time-sensitive ask, and I'll keep it short.

Steppe is a new member-governed Oregon nonprofit launching a community-owned, ad-free civic platform in Redmond this fall — verified local membership, \$4-a-month dues, community voting, full Spanish access, and surplus revenue flowing to local charities by member vote. We have filed (or are filing) for 501(c)(3) recognition, but a determination letter is months away, and several aligned funders — the Roundhouse Foundation's fall Open Call and the Oregon Community Foundation among them — require either a determination letter or a fiscal sponsor right now.

Would Connect Central Oregon consider serving as our fiscal sponsor for a six-to-twelve-month pass-through while our determination is pending — or, if that isn't a fit, point us to the Central

Oregon organization best positioned to? We would cover the standard administrative fee, and the agreement would provide that grants and donor relationships transfer to Steppe upon determination. The funds in view are restricted launch-capacity grants — Spanish-localization review, accessibility work, volunteer-moderator training, legal and insurance — not operating overhead.

I'd welcome a short conversation this week, and I'm glad to share our governance charter, the security audit, and a demonstration of the platform. Beyond sponsorship, I suspect there's a broader partnership worth exploring — your work in volunteerism, mentoring, and regional capacity maps closely onto what Steppe needs to grow well — but the sponsorship question is the urgent one.

With appreciation for your consideration,

Greg Chism

Founding Executive Director, Steppe

[EMAIL] · [PHONE] · [WEBSITE]

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